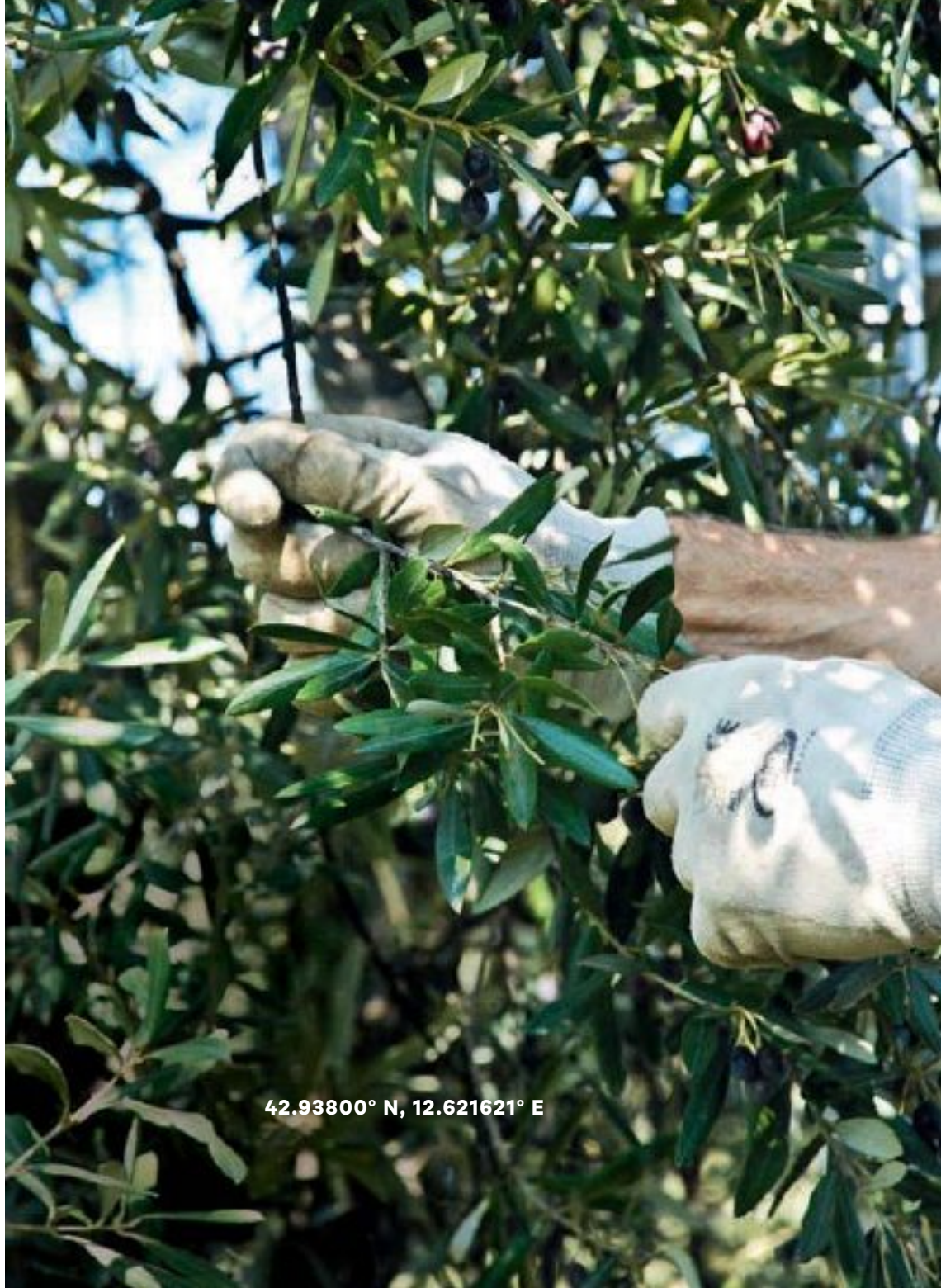




42.93800° N, 12.621621° E

Striking gold

Monte Vibiano, one of Italy's most venerable producers of olive oil, is now setting the pace for innovation

Words by Laura Martin



It isn't every day a meal of chopped cherry tomatoes drizzled with olive oil provides a business breakthrough. However, in the summer of 1998, Lorenzo Fasola Bologna and his dad sat down to enjoy this simple repast using a bottle of the previous autumn's olive oil. The oil, from their estate in Umbria, central Italy, had been frozen on the day of harvesting back in October – a huge no-no according to oil-keeping lore. However, once thawed and poured on the plate, the Fasola Bolognas realised it tasted just like it was fresh. Father and son were ecstatic. "When we ate it, we said, 'My goodness!'" recalls Lorenzo. "We'd never got to enjoy the two fresh together on the same day before. This was in July or August, when the tomatoes are ripe, and the olives are only ever harvested and pressed in November. The olive oil tasted exactly the same as the day we had pressed it, almost ten months before."

This simple discovery went on to revolutionise the family's business. They now press, bottle and immediately deep-freeze their olive oil with no exposure to air, preserving the oil's properties and producing lasting freshness. And in the last two decades their company, Castello Monte Vibiano Vecchio, has produced some of the world's best olive oil, which has earned top medals at the New York International Olive Oil Competition and a nod from the prestigious Gambero Rosso and Slow Food Guide among others.

Monte Vibiano, in the green Umbrian countryside, is one of the oldest olive oil presses in Italy, with a stone mill in the castle's grounds dating back to 300BC and olive trees over a thousand years old. But for the past two decades it has also earned a reputation for forward thinking. "When I took over in 1998, I made innovation a major part of the company, while also respecting the tradition of my family and country," says Lorenzo. "As soon as the olive is pressed, the ageing causes deterioration of the product. So when you freeze it, you stop this process, keeping it as fresh as possible and keeping as many of the health benefits as possible."

Extra-virgin olive oil not only tastes good, it is also reckoned to do you good. Enthusiasts attribute the higher life expectancy and natural well-being of Mediterranean folk to the high levels of antioxidant polyphenols within the oil, which they slosh into or over their fish-, fruit- and veg-rich diet. There's a strict regulatory body that must approve extra-virgin olive oil before it can be sold as such, with three key criteria to the appellation: the acidity must be less than 0.8 per cent; the oxidation level must be low; and there must be a total absence of defects. Freezing preserves all of these.

In 2015, Castello Monte Vibiano proved itself further as an industry pioneer when it began to work with the Italian National Research Council to use DNA profiling to verify the quality and heritage of the oil. While we might be more familiar with DNA testing in paternity suits and murder investigations, it now plays a major part in certifying the provenance of artisan foods, be they fine wines or rare herbs. Knowing exactly where your food has come from, that it's the genuine article, has become something of an obsession among ➤



Top to bottom Lorenzo Fasola Bologna, co-owner of Castello Monte Vibiano; the estate is in Umbria, central Italy; olives are harvested between October and December

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LIQUID GOLD

Below Some of olive trees at Monte Vibiano are more than 1,000 years old; there's also a mill that dates to 300BC



gastrophiles. In the US, spending on speciality and fine foods hit \$120.5 billion last year, while in the UK, sales of organic produce have been steadily rising, to £1.95 billion (\$2.5 billion) in 2015. But while foodies are increasingly happy to pay a higher price for a small-batch product or an ingredient of protected designation of origin, they want to be sure it's the real deal.

This technology is especially important for olive oil, as it's one of the food products most likely to be counterfeit – in the US, almost 70 per cent of extra-virgin olive oil is thought to be fake, as it is often cut with cheaper vegetable oils or dyed with chlorophyll to provide the distinctive golden-green colour and often herbaceous taste. But Lorenzo says that's not the reason they choose to analyse the DNA of their product – it's more to be completely transparent about the high quality of their oil: "I don't like to look to others, so for us, it's a matter of discipline and explaining what is coming from our terrain, and what kind of olives we're growing. I also think it's about being innovative and a way to prove we're constantly striving to be the best."

The eco-friendly company is raising the bar for the industry in another way too: they were certified as producing zero CO₂ emissions in 2010.



Indeed, they're the first farm in the world to achieve zero greenhouse gas emissions, through their investments in environmentally responsible agricultural production, using solar panels, electric vehicles and organic fertilisers.

Monte Vibiano food scientist Andrea Palazzetti says that an exceptional blend of oil starts with the *terroir* in which their 15,000 trees grow: "We have many fields with soil high in macro-elements and micronutrients that are perfect for olive cultivation; we are 500 metres [1,640 feet] above sea level; and we have hot air streaming in from nearby Lake Trasimeno: this is the perfect environment for the olive tree. We're also working with some centuries-old trees. Over the years the agricultural industry has stopped using some of the indigenous varieties we find in these ancient trees, but they produce the most incredible tastes and aromas."

When the olives are ripe to harvest, the staff begin fastidiously checking them, as the space of a few days can create a completely different-tasting oil. They then pick the olives, making sure they are not broken or crushed, and process them within six hours. This is regularly done in the night, as the lower temperature helps to conserve and store the oil, which is then bottled and frozen. The various varieties of olive oil are blended by master tasters to produce new flavour profiles that change with every harvest. For fans, there's a real joy to trying out these new blends every year, much as wine aficionados await Beaujolais season. And with it being DNA certified, oil enthusiasts are able to tell the whole root-to-fruit history of their purchase at their next dinner party.

For Monte Vibiano, the work to satisfy the demand from food enthusiasts for quality artisan goods continues. "It's great that judges on award panels think our olive oil is the best in the world, but I'm always striving to improve," says Lorenzo. "We're going to do so many experiments over the next 20 or 30 years to make it even better. You never stop learning on this job, and we'll never stop innovating." ■
Etihad Airways is proud to serve Castello Monte Vibiano olive oil in its First Class cabin

✈
Etihad offers one daily direct flight from Abu Dhabi to Rome.
Etihad.com



Going for gold

Join the worldwide olive oil trail

Olive Tree and Olive Oil Festival Emilia

Romagna, Italy
26 November 2017
winefood.emiliaromagna.com

This traditional festival held in the medieval town of Brisighella celebrates the local extra-virgin olive oil with food, wine and music.

Olio Nuovo Day Paris, France 16–20 January 2018 olio-nuovo-day.com

This five-day fest offers hundreds of olive oils from all over the Mediterranean with one thing in common: they're all fresh pressed from the previous season. Join tasting sessions and workshops.

Los Olivos Jazz and Olive Festival Santa Ynes Valley, California June 2018

jazzandolivefestival.org
There's a side of jazz served up at this California fest, which showcases 30 olive-based dishes from local chefs and the region's best oils.